

THE HARAPPAN CIVILIZATION

HARAPPAN CHRONOLOGY: REGIONAL ROOTS → HARAPPAN SPATIAL SYSTEM AND → URBAN-RURAL SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY → BUILT ORDER, WATER AND → THE HARAPPAN ECONOMY AS → INTERNAL AND OVERSEAS EXCHANGE

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g14 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 HARAPPAN CHRONOLOGY: REGIONAL ROOTS TO LOCALISATION

HARAPPAN CHRONOLOGY

REGIONAL ROOTS TO LOCALISATION

LATE/LOCALISATION C. 3300-2600 BCE C. 2600-1900 BCE C. 1900-1300

INTEGRATED URBAN-RURAL NETWORK; DECLINE

REGIONAL TRANSFORMATION.

EARLY/REGIONALISATION → MATURE/INTEGRATION → LATE/LOCALISATION c.

3300-2600 BCE c.

2600-1900 BCE c.

1900-1300 BCE regional towns/crafts shared weights, seals, de-urbanisation, local ceramics, and exchange networks script, urban

Civilisation = integrated urban-rural network; decline = regional transformation.

CHRONOLOGY / PHASE

- EARLY/REGIONALISATION → MATURE/INTEGRATION → LATE/LOCALISATION c.
- 3300-2600 BCE c.

MATERIAL / INSTITUTION

- 2600-1900 BCE c.
- 1900-1300 BCE regional towns/crafts shared weights, seals, de-urbanisation, local ceramics, and exchange networks script, urban systems settlement shifts,

IMPACT / LIMIT

- Civilisation = integrated urban-rural network; decline = regional transformation.
- EARLY/REGIONALISATION → MATURE/INTEGRATION → LATE/LOCALISATION c.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Civilisation = integrated urban-rural network; decline = regional transformation.

01

STAGE 01 HARAPPAN SPATIAL SYSTEM AND SITE ATLAS

HARAPPAN SPATIAL SYSTEM AND SITE ATLAS

MAKRAN EDGE

JAMMU FRONTIER

CORE INDUS

URBAN/CEMETERY SEQUENCE

GREAT BATH/DRAINS

PLOUGHED FIELD/FIRE INSTALLATIONS

FORTIFIED TOWN

WEST: Sutkagendor → Makran edge

NORTH: Manda → Jammu frontier

CORE INDUS: Harappa → urban/cemetery sequence

Mohenjo-daro → Great Bath/drains

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- WEST: Sutkagendor → Makran edge
- NORTH: Manda → Jammu frontier
- CORE INDUS: Harappa → urban/cemetery sequence
- Mohenjo-daro → Great Bath/drains
- GHAGGAR: Kalibangan → ploughed field/fire installations

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Banawali → fortified town
- EAST: Rakhigarhi → major Haryana complex
- Alamgirpur → eastern Late Harappan edge
- KUTCH: Dholavira → three-part city, reservoirs, signboard
- Surkotada → fortification

DEBATE / LEGACY

- GUJARAT: Lothal → basin/warehouse/craft debate
- Rangpur → regional sequence
- SINDH: Chanhudaro → craft centre; no classic citadel-lower-town profile

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: SINDH: Chanhudaro → craft centre; no classic citadel-lower-town profile.

02

STAGE 02 URBAN-RURAL SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY

URBAN-RURAL SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY

FARM/PASTORAL HAMLETS

CRAFT/ROUTE CENTRES

REGIONAL CITIES FOOD AND HERDS STORAGE SPECIALISED OUTPUT COORDINATION/CONSUMPTION

URBANISM DEPENDED ON RURAL SURPLUS AND RAW-MATERIAL CORRIDORS; CITIES

FARM/PASTORAL HAMLETS → VILLAGES → CRAFT/ROUTE CENTRES → REGIONAL CITIES food and herds storage specialised

output coordination/consumption weights + seals + transport + shared styles connect unequal regional domains.

Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- FARM/PASTORAL HAMLETS → VILLAGES → CRAFT/ROUTE CENTRES → REGIONAL CITIES food and herds storage specialised
- output coordination/consumption weights + seals + transport + shared styles connect unequal regional domains.

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.
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DEBATE / LEGACY

- output coordination/consumption weights + seals + transport + shared styles connect unequal regional domains.
- Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- FARM/PASTORAL HAMLETS → VILLAGES → CRAFT/ROUTE CENTRES → REGIONAL CITIES food and herds storage specialised
- output coordination/consumption weights + seals + transport + shared styles connect unequal regional domains.

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.
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DEBATE / LEGACY

- output coordination/consumption weights + seals + transport + shared styles connect unequal regional domains.
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ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.

03

STAGE 03

BUILT ORDER, WATER AND CIVIC MAINTENANCE

BUILT ORDER, WATER AND CIVIC MAINTENANCE

PLANNED STREETS + STANDARD BRICKS + PLATFORMS + COURTYARD

BATHING AREAS

COVERED DRAINS

SOAK PITS/INSPECTION ACCESS HOUSEHOLD INVESTMENT COLLECTIVE MAINTENANCE

DHOLAVIRA ADAPTS RESERVOIRS TO ARIDITY; MOHENJO-DARO STRESSES WELLS AND

PLANNED STREETS + STANDARD BRICKS + PLATFORMS + COURTYARD HOUSES wells/reservoirs → bathing

→ areas → covered drains → soak pits/inspection access household investment collective maintenance

→ Dholavira adapts reservoirs to aridity; Mohenjo-daro stresses wells and drains.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- PLANNED STREETS + STANDARD BRICKS + PLATFORMS + COURTYARD HOUSES wells/reservoirs → bathing
- areas → covered drains → soak pits/inspection access household investment collective maintenance

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Dholavira adapts reservoirs to aridity; Mohenjo-daro stresses wells and drains.
- PLANNED STREETS + STANDARD BRICKS + PLATFORMS + COURTYARD HOUSES wells/reservoirs → bathing

DEBATE / LEGACY

- areas → covered drains → soak pits/inspection access household investment collective maintenance
- Dholavira adapts reservoirs to aridity; Mohenjo-daro stresses wells and drains.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Dholavira adapts reservoirs to aridity; Mohenjo-daro stresses wells and drains.

04

STAGE 04

THE HARAPPAN ECONOMY AS A LINKED SYSTEM

THE HARAPPAN ECONOMY AS A LINKED SYSTEM

AGRICULTURAL-PASTORAL BASE WHEAT/BARLEY CATTLE COTTON FISHING/REGIONAL CROPS

CRAFT WORKSHOPS

CALIBRATED WEIGHTS

BEADS, SHELL, FAIENCE, POTTERY, COPPER/BRONZE; STONE REMAINS IMPORTANT.

SURPLUS → craft workshops → calibrated weights → seals/transport → exchange

→ AGRICULTURAL-PASTORAL BASE wheat/barley cattle cotton fishing/regional crops

→ CRAFTS: beads, shell, faience, pottery, copper/bronze; stone remains important.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- AGRICULTURAL-PASTORAL BASE wheat/barley cattle cotton fishing/regional crops
- SURPLUS → craft workshops → calibrated weights → seals/transport → exchange

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- CRAFTS: beads, shell, faience, pottery, copper/bronze; stone remains important.
- AGRICULTURAL-PASTORAL BASE wheat/barley cattle cotton fishing/regional crops

DEBATE / LEGACY

- SURPLUS → craft workshops → calibrated weights → seals/transport → exchange
- CRAFTS: beads, shell, faience, pottery, copper/bronze; stone remains important.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CRAFTS: beads, shell, faience, pottery, copper/bronze; stone remains important.

05

STAGE 05

INTERNAL AND OVERSEAS EXCHANGE CORRIDORS

INTERNAL AND OVERSEAS EXCHANGE CORRIDORS

RAW MATERIAL FLOW

INDUS CITIES

COPPER CORRIDOR

PRODUCTION ZONES

SHELL, CARNELIAN, COASTAL ROUTES

CRAFTS AND PORTS

MESOPOTAMIA; MELUHHA IN CUNEIFORM TEXTS

Baluchistan/Afghanistan → metals/stones → Indus cities

→ Rajasthan/Khetri → copper corridor → production zones

→ Gujarat/Kutch → shell, carnelian, coastal routes → crafts and ports

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- RAW MATERIAL FLOW
- Baluchistan/Afghanistan → metals/stones → Indus cities
- Rajasthan/Khetri → copper corridor → production zones

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Gujarat/Kutch → shell, carnelian, coastal routes → crafts and ports
- Indus/Makran/Gulf → Dilmun/Magan → Mesopotamia; Meluhha in cuneiform texts
- Trade evidence = imports + texts + seals + production; it does not prove colonies.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- Lothal basin has dockyard/reservoir interpretations: state the debate.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Lothal basin has dockyard/reservoir interpretations: state the debate.

06

STAGE 06

SOCIETY AND POLITY: EVIDENCE WITHOUT INVENTED KINGS

SOCIETY AND POLITY

EVIDENCE WITHOUT INVENTED KINGS

HOUSE VARIATION + SCARCE GOODS + CRAFT CONTROL +

NO SECURE PALACE, ROYAL TOMB OR DECIPHERED KING-LIST; HIERARCHY

COORDINATED INSTITUTIONS ARE CERTAIN; EMPIRE-LEVEL SOVEREIGNTY IS UNPROVEN.

SOURCE / MATERIAL

METHOD / DEBATE

HISTORICAL RESULT

- Indus/Makran/Gulf → Dilmun/Magan → Mesopotamia; Meluhha in cuneiform texts
- Trade evidence = imports + texts + seals + production; it does not prove colonies.

STAGE 06 SOCIETY AND POLITY: EVIDENCE WITHOUT INVENTED KINGS

COORDINATED INSTITUTIONS ARE CERTAIN; EMPIRE-LEVEL SOVEREIGNTY IS UNPROVEN.

METHOD / DEBATE

- corporate or mercantile elites?
- NO secure palace, royal tomb or deciphered king-list; hierarchy existed, form is open.

- VERDICT: coordinated institutions are certain; empire-level sovereignty is unproven.
- EVIDENCE: house variation + scarce goods + craft control + standards + public works centralised state?

STAGE 07 SCRIPT, SEALS AND RELIGION: EVIDENCE LADDER

SCRIPT LANGUAGE; PROTO-SHIVA; MOTHER-GODDESS SYSTEM; UNIVERSAL FIRE ALTARS

USE OBJECT + CONTEXT + DISTRIBUTION BEFORE ANALOGY.

METHOD / DEBATE

- **DISPUTED:** script language; proto-Shiva; mother-goddess system; universal fire altars
- **REJECT:** reading later Hindu doctrine directly into every Harappan image.

- Undeciphered script blocks direct access to office, belief and political vocabulary.
- Use object + context + distribution before analogy.

STAGE 08 DE-URBANISATION: INTERACTING REGIONAL CAUSES

CROPS, CRAFTS, VILLAGES

river shifts/floods + aridification + exchange contraction + maintenance stress weaker standards → city

▶ No invasion or single river explains all regions; timings and outcomes differ.

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- No invasion or single river explains all regions; timings and outcomes differ.
- river shifts/floods + aridification + exchange contraction + maintenance stress weaker standards → city

- contraction/abandonment → settlement redistribution loss; script, seals, large cities continuity: crops, crafts, villages
- No invasion or single river explains all regions; timings and outcomes differ.

STAGE 09 HARAPPAN ANSWER ARCHITECTURE: 10/15/20 MARKS

URBAN FORM

BENCHMARK: material uniformity indicates integration, not automatic political unity.

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- 20 MARKS: integration → site map → urban-rural economy → water/standards/trade
- society-polity evidence → script/ritual limits → transformation

- BENCHMARK: material uniformity indicates integration, not automatic political unity.
- CLOSE: a varied civilisation coordinated by standards, exchange and maintenance.

09

STAGE 09

HARAPPAN ANSWER ARCHITECTURE: 10/15/20 MARKS

HARAPPAN ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

10/15/20 MARKS

10 MARKS

SITE-FEATURE TRIAD

INTERPRETATION CAUTION

15 MARKS

SPATIAL SYSTEM

URBAN FORM

10 MARKS: phase → site-feature triad → mechanism → interpretation caution

15 MARKS: chronology → spatial system → urban form → economy → polity/religion limits

20 MARKS: integration → site map → urban-rural economy → water/standards/trade

society-polity evidence → script/ritual limits → transformation

BENCHMARK: material uniformity indicates integration, not automatic political unity.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

10 MARKS: phase → site-feature triad → mechanism → interpretation caution

15 MARKS: chronology → spatial system → urban form → economy → polity/religion limits

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

20 MARKS: integration → site map → urban-rural economy → water/standards/trade

society-polity evidence → script/ritual limits → transformation

DEBATE / LEGACY

BENCHMARK: material uniformity indicates integration, not automatic political unity.

CLOSE: a varied civilisation coordinated by standards, exchange and maintenance.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE: a varied civilisation coordinated by standards, exchange and maintenance.

10

STAGE 10

EVIDENCE LADDER AND CONFIDENCE CONTROL

EVIDENCE LADDER AND CONFIDENCE CONTROL

EVIDENCE LADDER

FROM SOURCE BOOK

STANDARD KNOWLEDGE

CURRENT AFFAIRS.

2. SITE LOCATION

RIVER SIGNATURE FIND

3. SPINDLE WHORLS ARE COMMON CRAFT EVIDENCE; SHELL/IVORY SCALES

SOURCE / MATERIAL	METHOD / DEBATE	HISTORICAL RESULT
EVIDENCE LADDER	2. Site Location / river Signature find	VERDICT: Source type controls the strength and limits of the historical claim.
1. = from source book = inference / standard knowledge = current affairs.	3. Spindle whorls are common craft evidence; shell/ivory scales and...	EVIDENCE LADDER

SOURCE / MATERIAL

EVIDENCE LADDER

1. = from source book = inference / standard knowledge = current affairs.

METHOD / DEBATE

2. Site Location / river Signature find

3. Spindle whorls are common craft evidence; shell/ivory scales and...

HISTORICAL RESULT

VERDICT: Source type controls the strength and limits of the historical claim.

EVIDENCE LADDER

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: Source type controls the strength and limits of the historical claim.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Source type controls the strength and limits of the historical claim.

11

STAGE 11

EXAMINER TRAPS AND CONTESTED BOUNDARIES

EXAMINER TRAPS AND CONTESTED BOUNDARIES

CLOSE DISTINCTIONS

1. EVIDENCE DISCIPLINE

CONTESTED CHRONOLOGY AND INTERPRETATION REMAIN

2. CONTESTED ISSUES COMPETING INTERPRETATIONS ARE ATTRIBUTED, EVIDENCED

3. INSCRIPTION AND COIN EVIDENCE

CONTEMPORARY NAMES, TITLES, CLAIMS AND

QUALIFICATION EARNS MARKS; FALSE CERTAINTY IS A HARD FAILURE.

CLOSE DISTINCTIONS

1. Evidence discipline: contested chronology and interpretation remain

2. Contested issues Competing interpretations are attributed, evidenced

3. Inscription and coin evidence: contemporary names, titles, claims and

VERDICT: Qualification earns marks; false certainty is a hard failure.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

CLOSE DISTINCTIONS

1. Evidence discipline: contested chronology and interpretation remain...

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

2. Contested issues Competing interpretations are attributed, evidenced...

3. Inscription and coin evidence: contemporary names, titles, claims and...

DEBATE / LEGACY

VERDICT: Qualification earns marks; false certainty is a hard failure.

CLOSE DISTINCTIONS

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: Qualification earns marks; false certainty is a hard failure.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Qualification earns marks; false certainty is a hard failure.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

1. SNAPSHOT & CORE IDEA

2. DEBATES & INTERPRETATIONS (HIGH-YIELD TABLE)

GENETICS AND HARAPPAN/VEDIC QUESTIONS — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

3. STUDY LINKS

4. MUST-KNOW FACTS (PRELIMS)

+ EXACT PYQ APPLICATION (2025 GS-I)

5. UPSC TRAPS

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

Mini-timeline

1. Snapshot & core idea

2. Debates & interpretations (high-yield table)

Genetics and Harappan/Vedic Questions — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

ADVANCED DEBATE

3. Study links

4. Must-Know Facts (Prelims)

+ Exact PYQ application (2025 GS-I)

5. UPSC Traps

LEGACY / NUANCE

7. Mains angles

Optional Advanced Studios: Distinct Refinements — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

A1. Urbanism, Households and Craft — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

A2. Standardisation and Authority — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.